A commentary on the essence of

The Jewel Ornament of Liberation

of Dharma Lord Gampopa

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Introduction to Part 4: The Method

I. Relaxing, reflecting and rejoicing

Cultivate the thought to free yourself and others

1. Please first relax
   physically and mentally.
   Then, just please feel we are so
   fortunate to get this precious
   opportunity to touch the wisdom
   of the Buddha.

2. The wisdom of the Buddha means
   special insight and compassion —
   that is the principal method
   of how to relax mentally,
   inner peace.

3. Now, we just reflect that
   everybody desires peace and
   happiness, and everybody desires
   to be free from suffering;
   this is the reality nature.

4. On the basis of this,
   we cultivate our altruistic
   thought to free ourselves
   and all sentient beings
   from the confusion,
   and to heal our mind and the
   minds of all sentient beings.

5. Today I will touch on
   the subject of the
   Buddha's teaching.
   Just appreciate and rejoice.

6. With this, please take a
   deep breath: inhale fully,
   and exhale all our tension,
   physically and mentally.

7. Inhale all the Buddha's wisdom
   and compassion into us,
   and we meditate;
   it heals our body and mind.
   Exhale all our confusion.

8. Once more, please inhale fully
   all the wisdom and compassion of
   the Buddha, and exhale all our
   confusion and suffering.

9. Then the mind just relaxes
   like the nature of space —
   an unconfined state of the mind,
   total freedom,
   not occupied by confusion,
   the cause of suffering.

II. Reviewing what we have touched on so far

The seed, the working basis and the spiritual master

1. These next few months we are
   studying the Jewel Ornament of
   Liberation, a book compiled
   by Dharma Lord Gampopa,
   an enlightened master.

2. This book that Gampopa wrote has
   served so greatly in benefiting
   sentient beings through many
   centuries; beginners and highly
   realized ones, great scholars,
   they all appreciate this
   special book.

3. Everyone uses this book as a guideline; they follow the path step by step, so that everyone can be free from the vicious cycle of samsara.

4. This book has six topics: the primary cause; the working basis; the spiritual master; the method, the instruction of the spiritual master; the result, Buddhahood; and the activities of the Buddha.

5. So far we have touched on the primary cause: the innate goodness, a seed, the potential seed for enlightenment, to see the effulgent nature of the mind.

6. As you see in samsara, everywhere, all over the world, people and animals are suffering so much — those who are rich, those who are poor, those with a high status and those without, young or old. Everyone is going through a vicious cycle in their life due to the lack of the wisdom to see the effulgent nature of the mind.

7. Our mind is occupied by this ignorance, bewilderment; we are in the jungle of the confusion. So this book first starts with how much potential, the seed, we have to achieve total peace and happiness. Dharmakaya is pervaded to all the sentient beings. So first we appreciate this.

8. To reveal the total nature of the effulgence, the enlightenment, we need a working basis, the precious human life — physically the leisures and endowments, and mentally trusting, longing, and clear faith. Thus, well equipped, the working basis has all the ability to purify all our obscurations.

9. But that much is not enough: we need the spiritual master who has all these excellent qualities for enlightenment to show to others — the ability, the skill, the altruistic mind, the bodhicitta.

III. The method, instructions of the spiritual master

Why I need to study and practice the Dharma

1. Now, from today, we touch on the instruction, the method — how we can study and practice these precious teachings.

2. We should make sense for ourselves why do we need to study and practice the Dharma, not just as a religion, but as a cause, as a condition, for how we can be free from the vicious cycle of this confusion, the suffering.

3. Everybody in the world — politically, economically, technologically — keeps their life so busy because they want to achieve some peace and happiness, to be free from suffering, to secure their life for the better.

4. Now, the Dharma teaching that the Buddha taught is not just to secure us physically, but mentally. It is a very sophisticated technology that the Buddha has developed, with which sentient beings are well equipped.

5. But in the modern world there is no clear instruction for this. Even in this modern 21st century, science and technology are highly appreciated, but all are designed for the outer phenomena, not the inner phenomena; here we are touching the inner phenomena.

6. Now I read this introduction to part four, which is the method, the instructions of the spiritual master; it is short but very condensed, and it makes such a very important point.

7. It is very important we read this, then I will try to explain whatever I can, and then you yourself should, in your mind, see that. We should have such a convinced wisdom, the reason why we need to follow these teachings — not as a religious training, but as a universal requirement on how to be free from suffering, on how to achieve total peace and happiness.

8. This content is very important for modern education. All these ancient wisdoms should be supported by modern education; these Dharma teachings are totally agreeable with modern education — it’s not an old system.

IV. Why are we still in samsara?

We were overpowered by four obstacles

1. *Since we have the primary cause, Buddha-nature, we have come from a continuous stream since beginningless samsara. At some time, we must have gained a precious human life and also met with a spiritual master.* Not so often, but just imagine: just like in this life, there are so many people who have encountered some spiritual masters, an opportunity to study and meditate.

2. What went wrong? *What faults have prevented us from attaining Buddhahood in the past?* What obstacles did we face? What impediments did we encounter? Why are we still in samsara?

3. This is a very important question to reflect on ourselves. It is the way to have conviction; this will help us to follow the path without flinching, without going back, going only forward.

4. Otherwise, sometimes we think, "Buddha's teachings are beautiful, wonderful, but I was not born with that. It's okay, I'm happy. My life is all right." There are so many like that, but we have to look at the complete picture of our life.

5. Why have we not been freed from samsara? So the answer is here: *We have been overpowered by the four obstacles* — four different impediments, four different obstacles we encountered.

6. Gampopa asked such an important question for us, because we don't know which questions we should ask — so that we wake up: "I can see there's a Buddha nature within me; now I have a precious human life. Still, I cannot practice so well. Why?"

7. *What are the four obstacles or impediments to the attainment of Buddhahood?* First, *being attached to this life's activities* — not only business, not only politics; even sometimes we use Dharma practice just for this life's benefit.

8. Second, *being attached to the pleasure of samsara* means in the god realm, in the human realm. We try to make this life as perfect as possible; then, if we believe in the next life, we hope for a human rebirth in a good place. Some humans live like in the god realm, with such a joyous, good life: "This is enough for me. I feel good about this. I don't need Dharma practice; I don't need to meditate. I'm just well off."

9. Third, *being attached to peace* means sometimes we feel samsara is a state of suffering — occasionally good, but always with some problems, difficulties: "I cannot be totally free from that kind of suffering in samsara. I must be free from samsara, but for myself; I cannot do this for others. I need myself to be free from this vicious cycle of suffering." So I am attached to my own peace, liberation.

10. Fourth, *not understanding the method by which enlightenment is achieved*. For example: "Yes, I want to achieve complete enlightenment, but I don't know how. Can you tell me?"

11. We encounter these four, but not necessarily all four — any one of those. Some may not be so attached to this life's activities, nor to the pleasure of samsara; they want to help others and are not so attached to their own peace, but they don't know how to attain Buddhahood.

12. So first we should get these four very important points. Just open our heart; don't take it as a personal "I like" or "don't like," but look whether it makes sense or not.

V. How can these four obstacles be dispelled?

By practicing the instruction heard from the spiritual master

1. *How can these four obstacles be dispelled? They are dispelled — gotten rid of — by practicing the instruction heard from the spiritual master.* That's how the spiritual master is so important, and how important it is for the spiritual master to have all these qualities.

2. It's not the title.
   Sometimes we are so much involved with the title — "What title do you have? What title does he/she have?" — and not looking at the qualities. It's very important to have the qualities, the ability to help others.

3. *How many instructions of the spiritual master are there? In summary: meditation on impermanence* — first, to release attachment to this life.

4. Second, *meditation on the faults of samsara and cause and result*.
   The faults of samsara means the suffering of samsara, the unsatisfactory nature of samsara; no matter how much we enjoy in samsara, never satisfied.
   And the cause of that, and the result.

5. Third, *meditation on loving-kindness and compassion*.
   Everyone has some kind of love and compassion, whether emotionally, out of attachment, or else.
   But here it means love and compassion to all sentient beings.

6. Fourth, *various elements of the cultivation of bodhicitta*:
   through different methods we cultivate bodhicitta.
   Bodhicitta practice is how to attain Buddhahood.
   These four comprise the instruction of the spiritual master.

7. *To restate,* to make more clear how to get out of these four obstacles they are instructions on the meditation practice regarding such four.

8. It's not enough to just say, for example, "I understand impermanence"; it's not enough just to say, "I know samsara is a state of suffering."
   But here meditation practice means to bring it into our heart, then see that nature, convince ourselves, and follow the path.
   That is what is meant by meditation practice.

9. These are the direct methods to counteract, to dispel the obstacles.
   When we are totally convinced about the impermanence of all phenomena — when we see that in the heart and just say, "Yes, I can see it" — then it helps to release attachment to this life.

10. When we see the suffering of samsara, one after another, it helps to release the attachment to the pleasure of samsara.

11. When you see all sentient beings
as our mother, our sister,
our brother, who are suffering,
then it helps to release the
attachment to only individual
self-liberation.

12. Then, when you know the
bodhicitta practice,
then you open the door towards
complete Buddhahood.

13. Look at these four obstacles
carefully; investigate.
Every country has a
constitution, but this is the
constitution of the Buddha's
teaching to achieve Buddhahood —
the complete constitution,
no more, no less.

14. When we have this constitution
understood in our heart,
the practitioner feels so happy:
"Yes! Now I know.
I was practicing Dharma for
many years, but didn't know
really what for, or how."
Or, "I like to meditate;
really, I want to.
I feel the suffering of samsara
is so much, but I didn't know.
But now I know what this means."
And the joy you receive cannot
be replaced by anything,
and when you are working
for enlightenment,
all the hardships are nothing.

VI. Contemplating impermanence

It remedies attachment to this life's activities

1. That's why the life story of
Milarepa is always so beautiful:
he went through that life but he
went through it so joyfully.

2. From outside he looked
so poor, so weak.
Some hunters went up the
mountain and saw Milarepa with
nothing to eat, nothing to wear,
in a cave, and they said,
"What a poor man you are!
You didn't know how to live
your life."

3. Milarepa answered, "I know
what I'm doing, you don't.
This is because of the
wisdom of Marpa, from whom
I received the teachings."
He knew he would definitely be
free from the vicious cycle
of samsara.

4. And he was so excited
to go through purifying
all these inveterate,
deeply rooted habits.
One needs such courage.
Dharma practice is not for
weak people. People ask why
are monks and nuns ordained?
We need such a courageous mind,
a courageous body, strength
physically and mentally,
and go forward.

5. This is for such wise people,
   weak people cannot handle this.
   So we should have
   such great joy;
   that's why this is so precious.
   These points are so important
   first, to capture the root, the
   rudiments of Dharma practice.

6. *Thus, contemplating the subject of impermanence remedies attachment to this life's activities.*

7. Not only those who are
   not Buddhist, but even
   Buddhist business people,
   Buddhist politicians,
   are so corrupted for this life,
   because they are so attached
   to this life's achievement.
   They have not received
   the Buddha's message;
   they misunderstood it.

8. We should have a clear
   picture of what this means.
   It doesn't mean we don't
   care for this life.
   Of course we have to eat, have
   a place to live, wear clothes;
   we need to sustain this life.
   But how much do you need?
   We have one stomach, one mouth.
   If you eat too much it's a
   problem.

9. Some people are totally focused
   on this life: "Can you say some
   prayers so that my business is
   very successful, so that I'm
   promoted to a higher status,
   get a good title?" All the
   focus is only for this life.
   We even forget the next life,
   let alone enlightenment.

10. Meditate on this;
    reflect on this.
    This impermanence helps us to
    remove our obstacle of focusing
    only on this life.

VII. The remedies for the latter three obstacles

Reflections on samsara, compassion and the supreme bodhicitta

1. Then, *reflecting on the faults of samsara*.
   The faults of samsara means
   the suffering of samsara.
   In the human realm,
   we are not always bad:
   sometimes it's a beautiful day,
   our health is good, and we have
   very good food to enjoy — "Life
   is beautiful, life is perfect."
   But it's not always that way.

2. Sometimes things go in the
   wrong direction and we suffer:
   "What should I do?
   Can you say some prayers?
   My life is not going well."
   So we have to reflect on
   both sides, good and bad —
   but it is always changing.

3. *…and on karma, cause and its result, remedies attachment to the pleasure of samsara.* So don't be too attached to samsara: whether you are born in the god realm or in the human realm, still there's suffering.

4. Of course, in the hell realm, as hungry ghosts or animals, the suffering is so profound, so deep. Still, in the human realm, you can see the suffering of the very rich people, of the leaders of the powerful countries — how much suffering they have!

5. Sometimes you feel, "Why do you want to be the leader of a country?" Still, people are attached to that, without knowing. So if you see these teachings, then you say, "Oh, there are some alternatives."

6. Third, *meditating on loving-kindness and compassion remedies* — purifies, is the antidote for — *attachment to the pleasure of individual peace*. This peace is not samsaric peace; this peace is the liberation, like a partial nirvana.

7. And the fourth, *cultivating the supreme bodhicitta*. Everybody has a mind, but the mind which desires to attain Buddhahood, the mind which cultivates bodhicitta, is the supreme mind.

8. The mind which desires to help all sentient beings is such a sublime mind, such a precious mind. *That is the antidote for not understanding the method by which to achieve enlightenment.*

VIII. Why am I practicing Dharma?

The real enemy and the real medicine

1. Please reflect on this, the four obstacles and remedies, very carefully. It's good to repeat, and then maybe memorize; then meditate on this: "Why am I practicing Dharma?" This is the real wisdom of the Buddha, how to uproot the total suffering.

2. How many great empowerments have you received? Such highest yoga deity empowerments you have received many times, not only once. It is precious; it is fortunate to receive such powerful deity empowerments.

3. But how much benefit
   did you get from this?
   It has not much affected your
   mind to free it from our mental
   afflictions.

4. So all our Dharma practice,
   deep down, if we look carefully:
   we need to purify the mind.
   That's what the Buddha said.

5. The real enemy of sentient
   beings is our mental
   afflictions. The person we say
   is "my enemy" is temporary:
   one day he or she is your enemy,
   the next day they can become
   such a wonderful friend.
   But the mental afflictions,
   negative thoughts, we cannot
   become friends with at all.
   They always take away our peace
   and happiness.

6. Mental afflictions will always
   destroy our peace and happiness.
   Look at desire, attachment;
   look at our anger,
   aversion, jealousy.
   As soon as they arise in our
   heart, they take away all
   our peace and happiness —
   and without knowing,
   we blame somebody else outside:
   "I feel miserable because he
   or she did this."

7. These four obstacles and
   the remedies are four very,
   very important points. These
   remedies are the real medicine;
   they can heal our mind.
   Our mind is so wounded,
   so much wounded.

8. The wisdom, the love, the
   compassion and the bodhicitta
   are the real ambrosia, undefiled
   ambrosia, undefiled nectar.
   They heal our body,
   they will heal our mind,
   make our mind fresh,
   and they will make our life
   very productive, useful.

IX. The reality-nature of samsara

Nothing to do with Buddhism

1. What we are studying and
   practicing has nothing to
   do with Buddhism; it is the
   reality nature of samsara.
   Everywhere in the world you
   see suffering because of these
   mental afflictions.

2. Of course, there are
   some outside forces —
   when there's no rain, a flood —
   that give us suffering,
   but once in a while.
   These mental afflictions give us
   suffering 24 hours, every day
   in our life, life after life,
   no matter where we are reborn.

3. So the Buddha's teaching is this: true peace, peace within. It takes time, because we are so perniciously habituated; we need to repeat again and again.

4. We need these powerful teachings to purify and replace [the afflictions] by the wisdom, our Buddha nature. Our Buddha nature is the total peace; it is the embodiment of all the wisdom that we need to reveal.

5. To reveal that, first we need to study and practice the Buddha's teaching; we need to meditate ourselves, and practice.

X. All teachings are included in bodhicitta

Depending on the spiritual master

1. *These are the factors used to cultivate the mind and to develop bodhicitta.* These are all methods: impermanence is a method, reflecting on the suffering of samsara and on karma and its result is a method, loving-kindness and compassion are all a method to develop bodhicitta. At the end of the day, our focus is bodhicitta, but we need all these factors.

2. That's why it's called *various factors: from the time one starts taking refuge until one meditates on the meaning of the two selflessnesses, or from the five paths until the ten bhumis, all Dharma teachings are included in the cultivation of bodhicitta.*

3. *Some practices form the foundation through which to cultivate the enlightened mind, some are the objects of the cultivation of the mind, some are methods to cultivate the mind, some are the training in the cultivation of the mind* — the mind means bodhicitta — *some are the beneficial effects of the cultivation of the mind, and some are the results of the cultivation of the mind, so all the Mahayana teachings are included in cultivation of the mind, bodhicitta.*

4. *Therefore, all these instructions are imparted, given by the spiritual master,* depending on the spiritual master. So we depend on the spiritual master.

5. *The Planting of the Noble Stalk says, "The spiritual master is the source of all virtuous teachings." The attainment of omniscience depends on the instructions of the spiritual master.*

6. So the spiritual master who
gave us these teachings is so
precious, so kind, so generous.

7. In any school,
when a good teacher gives
you all this wisdom,
the students become wonderful.
But the student also has a
responsibility: those students
who are very attentive,
who follow the advice,
the instructions given by
the teacher respectfully,
attentively, become much better.

8. In the Dharma it is the same —
interdependent.
When the student attends
respectfully, with awareness,
with mindfulness,
you can get so much benefit.
If you are always arguing,
you can get nothing.

9. Of course, one should have the
special insight to investigate
right or wrong. The Buddha
gave us all this perfect
opportunity and explained
everything so perfectly.
As we went through, he explained
the qualities and the ability a
spiritual master should have,
and then how much responsibility
the student has.

10. So I think this introduction
is very important.
Repeat this; be aware of
this again and again:
“Why am I practicing Dharma?
Why should I do this?”